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THE LONE RANGERS (Clockwise) Shooter Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore kisses his silver at the 2004 Olympics; Anju Bobby George's 6.83 m long jump at the same edition remains the national best; Karnam Malleswari became the first Indian woman to bring home an Olympic medal in 2000

the 2003 Athletics World Championship, becoming the first Indian to win a medal there. Even though she considers her 2005 gold at the World Athletics Final to be her finest showing, it was the record she made a year before at the Olympics—soaring 6.83 m across that strip of tantalising sand—that is her personal, and the national, best.

Shooting also saw a new posse of gunslingers ride into town. Jaspal Rana was already there on main street, crafting a remarkable career. But Abhinav Bindra arrived, not even 20 when he won a silver and gold at the 2002 Commonwealth Games in Manchester. Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, who bagged a gold there, hit a higher target two years later at Athens by winning India's first shooting silver at the Olympics. Bindra's bullseye would come, soon. ■